infection, with an SOP in place for the protection of doctors and staff. The states have been asked to focus on contact tracing and quarantining of those who have met an infected person. "As monkeypox is less transmissible than Covid and symptoms show up in a week or two, if the numbers are less, it can be contained by contact tracing and isolation," says Dr Kang.

Contact tracing has already been done for the three cases in Kerala and all are in quarantine, and the Delhi government has been asked to do the same for the only case in the capital—a 31-year-old man from West Delhi. According to LNJP officials, 14 contacts have been traced already and are in isolation with none showing symptoms till date. While the cases in Kerala had a history of foreign travel, the patient in Delhi has no travel history, leading to some worries that local transmission could have begun. "We have a special team to deal with monkeypox patients," says Dr Kumar of LNJP, the hospital where anyone in Delhi showing symptoms will be sent to.

Given that the demand for smallpox vaccines will soon rise globally, experts say it would be advisable to place orders for essential antiviral drugs and vaccines soon. "We need to prepare. Vaccines for the vulnerable or those coming into close contact with confirmed cases should be looked into. We also need to build our testing capacity and strategy, and include private labs too," says Dr Kang.

Though monkeypox has a known cure and vaccine, it will take time for the world to reach the manufacturing capacity needed for everyone to access them. Besides focusing on surveillance, testing and contact tracing, India should also keep an eye on vaccine and drug availability. Memories of the discomfort and scars caused by smallpox should drive us to take on this new disease with foresight. ■

UTTAR PRADESH

RUMBLINGS IN THE YOGI REGIME

By Prashant Srivastava



ANI

TUG-OF-WAR CM Yogi Adityanath with deputy CM Brajesh Pathak (left) at an exhibition

Just four months into its second term, the Yogi Adityanath-led BJP government in Uttar Pradesh is in fire-fighting mode over an unseemly tussle involving a slew of ministers and top figures in the bureaucracy. Several cabinet ministers have complained and Dinesh Khatik, Dalit leader and MoS in the Jal Shakti department, set off some extra panic by sending in his resignation (later retracted after the BJP top leadership intervened).

State BJP leaders blame it on the "free hand" Yogi has given officials, who often overrule even the ministers in charge. The issue started with a clash between Brajesh Pathak, the deputy CM and health minister, and Amit Mohan Prasad, additional chief secretary (ACS), medical and health. On July 4, Pathak sought a report over the transfers made in the department in his absence. Matters came to a head after the deputy CM wrote Prasad (who is considered close to Yogi) a letter seeking an explanation, so much so the CM had to order an inquiry.

GIVEN A 'FREE HAND', OFFICIALS OFTEN EVEN OVERRULE MINISTERS

Prasad is also under the scanner on two other issues. The prime minister's office has asked the UP government to look into allegations of payments being held up for government projects handled by a private group and the state Lokayukta has asked for clarifications regarding the purchase of "substandard" PPE and other medical equipment during the first Covid wave.

In the public works department, minister Jitin Prasada's OSD Anil Kumar Pandey has been transferred while five others were suspended following allegations of corruption. Prasada went to Delhi to meet the high command to discuss the matter but was apparently unable